1 Building Blocks for Effective Messages

Module 1 Business Communication, Management, and Success

Module 2 Adapting Your Message to Your Audience

Module 3 Communicating Across Cultures

Module 4 Planning, Writing, and Revising

Module 5 Designing Documents, Slides, and Screens

Module

1 Business Communication, Management, and Success

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Module 1 explores with you the importance of communication in the business world. After completing the module, you should be able to

- **LO 1-1** Recognize myths about on-the-job writing.
- **LO 1-2** Distinguish business communication from other school writing.
- **LO 1-3** Explain accomplishments through communication.
- **LO 1-4** Understand costs for business communication.
- **LO 1-5** Define criteria for effective messages.
- **LO 1-6** Apply strategies for communication analysis.
- **LO 1-7** Apply strategies for creative thinking.

If a word could sum up life in the early 21st century, it would be "change."

Changes to politics, diversity, education, technology, fuel costs, and business practices have altered the pace and quality of our lives. While change is ever constant, the scope of change over the past decade has been startling. Consider how with a cell phone and Internet connection, one person now can run a business globally or how workers can be employed from overseas or from the local labor pool. More students are going to college than ever before, millions of American workers are becoming eligible to retire, and millions of new workers are entering the job market—some with very different expectations than those of previous generations.

Americans, and indeed much of the world's population, also felt the stunning economic turbulence that erupted in the first decade of the 21st century. Foreclosures soared, unemployment rose past 10%, and foreign-born workers with H-1B visas found themselves heading back to their home countries for greener pastures.[1]

Unless you have a fairy godmother, you'll need to know how to communicate.



Copyright © 1993 Warren Miller/The New Yorker Collection, www.cartoonbank.com.

As this book goes to press, the U.S. economy continues to improve, but for millions of Americans struggling to make ends meet, the improvements have yet to affect their day-to-day lives. At least one thing is clear, though: workers with high-level skills and education continue to have the best chance of weathering the economic turbulence.

For instance, at the same time there were more than 600,000 job openings in education and health services, there were only 67,000 openings in construction. A lack of talent caused many jobs in the former—which typically require a higher level of education—to go unfilled.[2]

Of course, no one is immune to the problems. There are plenty of skilled employees who are unemployed or underemployed. Data suggest that college graduates under the age of 25 and with bachelor's degrees are facing one of the bleakest job markets in years.[3] But you increase your chances of success with the more you know and the more you can do. In particular, "soft skills," such as communication skills, become even more important as prospective employers scrutinize job applications.

Many Americans are challenged, however, by their level of English-language literacy. The last large-scale study of U.S. literacy by the National Endowment for the Arts, for instance, found that more American adults are not even reading one book a year, and the number of adults with bachelor's degrees deemed proficient in reading prose dropped from 40% to 31% in a decade.[4] A literacy study funded by the Pew Charitable Trust found that more than half of graduating students at four-year colleges and 75% at two-year colleges lack the literacy to handle complex, real-life tasks, such as analyzing news stories and understanding credit card offers.[5]

Work requires communication. People communicate to plan products and services; hire, train, and motivate workers; coordinate manufacturing and delivery; persuade customers to buy; and bill them for the sale. For many business, nonprofit, community, and government organizations, the "product" is information or a service rather than something tangible. Information and services are created and delivered by communication. In every organization, communication is the way people get their points across, get work done, and get recognized for their contributions.



Carnegie Speech is among companies providing English language training in an age of globalization, in this case to pilots who are non-native speakers of English. Beyond reading and writing, pilots must be able to pronounce words sufficiently so there is no confusion with the control tower. The potential for disaster is great enough that the United Nations issued new recommendations to improve English-language acquisition, citing past accidents where the lack of proficiency in English was a factor.

Source: Joe Sharkey, "English Skills a Concern as Global Aviation Grows," *The New York Times,* May 21, 2012, http://www.nytimes.com/2012/05/22/business/english-skills-a-concern-as-global-aviation-grows.html?_r=1.



A National Association of Colleges and Employers survey revealed that the ability to work in a team structure and to verbally communicate with persons inside and outside the organization topped the list of skills employers want in job candidates. The findings dovetail with those of the Partnership for 21st Century Skills, which found that 99% of people surveyed felt that success in the global economy depends on developing critical thinking and analytical skills, with 88% of those surveyed feeling that schools should also focus on teaching such skills as communication. Of the 14 skill sets offered for ranking, reading comprehension rated the highest in importance.

Sources: "Job Outlook: The Candidate Skills/Qualities Employers Want," The National Association of Colleges and Employers, October 26, 2011, http://www.naceweb.org/s10262011/candidate_skills_employer_qualities/; and "Beyond the Three Rs: Voter Attitudes Toward 21st Century Skills (Key Findings)," November 23, 2007, The Partnership for 21st Century Skills, www.21stcenturyskills.org/documents/p21_pollreport_2pg.pdf.

Communication takes many forms. **Verbal communication,** or communication that uses words, includes

- Face-to-face or phone conversations
- Meetings
- Text, e-mail, and voice-mail messages
- Letters and memos
- Reports

Nonverbal communication does not use words. Examples include

- Pictures
- Company logos
- Gestures and body language
- Who sits where at a meeting
- How long someone keeps a visitor waiting

Even in your first job, you'll communicate. You'll read information; you'll listen to instructions; you'll ask questions; you may solve problems with other workers in teams. In a manufacturing company, hourly workers travel to a potential customer to make oral sales presentations. In an insurance company, clerks answer customers' letters. Even "entry-level" jobs require high-level skills in reasoning, mathematics, and communicating. As a result, communication ability consistently ranks first among the qualities that employers look for in college graduates.[6]



Experts predict that globalization will continue to revolutionize business and industry throughout the upcoming years, transforming economies in the process. Here, workers inspect a tanker at Hyundai Heavy industries, Inc., a South Korean manufacturer of industrial robots, construction equipment, and electric and electronic systems that is also the world's largest shipbuilder. For companies with an eye toward being global leaders, effective communication is vital, whether to ensure smooth operations, cultivate strong relationships with diverse clients, or increase market share in a competitive environment. Of course, organizations with more local aspirations benefit from effective communication, too!

Communication affects all levels of work. Training specialists Brad Humphrey and Jeff Stokes identify communication skills as being among the most important for modern supervisors.[7] Andrew Posner, a career counselor, advises that employees looking to make a career change need such "transferable skills" as the ability to "analyze, write, persuade, and manage."[8]

Employers clearly want employees who communicate well, yet a staggering 40 million people in the United States alone have limited literacy skills, including some college graduates.[9] According to one report by the College Board's National Commission on Writing, states spend more than $220 million annually on remedial writing training for their employees, and corporations may spend $3.1 billion to fix problems from writing deficiencies; two-thirds of private-sector employers surveyed said writing was an important responsibility for employees.[10]

Because writing skills are so valuable, good writers earn more. Linguist Stephen Reder has found that among people with two- or four-year degrees, workers in the top 20% of writing ability earn, on average, more than three times as much as workers whose writing falls into the worst 20%.[11]

The conclusion is simple: Good communication skills are vital in today's workplace. Technology, especially through e-mail, instant messaging, and cell phones, is making the globe a smaller and busier place, one where messages must be understood immediately. Traditional paper messages flourish, even as electronic channels expand our ability to reach more people. The better an employee's communication skills are, the better his or her chance for success.



For U.S. elementary and middle school students, significant gains in math and science on standardized tests have been offset by only modest gains in reading skills. In 1992, for instance, 29% of fourth-grade students were proficient in reading, but nearly 20 years later, that number had risen only five percentage points. There were no gains at all from 2008 to 2009.

Source: Sam Dillon, "Since 1990s, U.S. Students' Math Has Sharpened, But Reading Lags," *The New York Times,* November 1, 2011, http://www.nytimes.com/2011/11/02/education/us-students-math-skills-sharpen-but-reading-lags.html.

Will I really have to write? LO 1-1

▶ *Yes. A lot.*

Claims that people can get by without writing are flawed.

Claim 1: Secretaries will do all my writing.
Reality: Because of automation and restructuring, secretaries and administrative assistants are likely to handle complex tasks such as training, research, and database management for several managers. Managers are likely to take care of their own writing, data entry, and phone calls.[12]

Claim 2: I'll use form letters or templates when I need to write.
Reality: A **form letter** is a prewritten fill-in-the-blank letter designed to fit standard situations. Using a form letter is OK if it's a good letter. But form letters cover only routine situations. The higher you rise, the more frequently you'll face situations that aren't routine and that demand creative solutions.

Claim 3: I'm being hired as an accountant, not a writer.
Reality: Almost every entry-level professional or managerial job requires you to write e-mail messages, speak to small groups, and write paper documents. People who do these things well are more likely to be promoted beyond the entry level.

Claim 4: I'll just pick up the phone.
Reality: Important phone calls require follow-up letters, memos, or e-mail messages. People in organizations put things in writing to make themselves visible, to create a record, to convey complex data, to make things convenient for the reader, to save money, and to convey their own messages more effectively. "If it isn't in writing," says a manager at one company, "it didn't happen." Writing is an essential way to make yourself visible, to let your accomplishments be known.



Some research has found less correlation between college majors and success in the workplace than might be expected. A study by Payscale, Inc., for instance, found that history majors who pursued business careers earned as much on average as those who majored in business. Much to the chagrin of his father, CNN's Ted Turner majored in Classics, and Michael Eisner, former head of The Walt Disney Company and at one time the highest-paid executive in the U.S., graduated with a Bachelor's Degree in English. George Brown College found that "most employers cite communication skills as the most important skill

(*continued*)

Don't I know enough about communication? LO 1-2

▶ *Business communication differs from other school writing.*

Although both business communication and other school writing demand standard edited English, in other ways the two are very different.

(*continued*)
for a candidate to possess," even though many people, such as Millennial students surveyed, believe experience is more important.

Source: Zac Bissonnette, "Your College Major May Not Be as Important as You Think," *The New York Times,* November 3, 2010, http://thechoice.blogs.nytimes.com/2010/11/03/major/.



Site to See

Go to
www.mindtools.com/pages/article/newTMM_36.htm
to test your interpersonal skills.



The National Assessment of Adult Literacy, a study by the U.S. Department of Education, showed that Mississippi has improved adult literacy in every one of its counties. Some other states, however, saw an increase in adult illiteracy, and one in seven U.S. adults is challenged to read anything more complex than a child's picture book.

Source: Greg Toppo, "Literacy Study: 1 in 7 Adults are Unable to Read this Story," *USAToday.* January 8, 2009, http://www.usatoday.com/news/education/2009-01-08-adult-literacy_N.htm.

Purpose

- The purpose of school writing is usually to show that you have learned the course material and to demonstrate your intelligence.
- The purpose of business communication is to meet an organizational need. No one will pay you to write something that he or she already knows.

Audience

- The audiences for school writing are limited: usually just the instructor and the other students. The real audience is "an educated person." Even if the instructor disagrees with your views, if they are well-supported, the paper can earn a good grade. The instructor is paid, in part, to read your papers and will read them even if they are boring.
- The audiences for business communication include people both inside and outside the organization (▶▶ Module 2). Real audiences pay attention to messages only if they seem important, relevant, and interesting.

Information

- Information in school writing may be new to you but is rarely new to your instructor.
- Information in business communication is usually new to your reader. (If it isn't, you have to work extra hard to make it interesting.)

Organization

- School writing often follows the traditional essay form, with a thesis statement up front, paragraphs of evidence, and a final concluding paragraph.
- Business communication is organized to meet the psychological needs of the reader. Most often, the main point comes up front (▶▶ Modules 10–12).

Style

- The style for school writing is often formal. Big words and long sentences and paragraphs are often rewarded.
- The style for business communication is friendly, not formal. Short words and a mix of sentence and paragraph lengths are best (▶▶ Modules 15 and 16).

Document Design

- School writing often rewards long paragraphs. Papers are often double spaced, with no attention to visual design.
- Businesspeople want to be able to skim documents. Headings, lists, and single-spaced paragraphs with double spacing between paragraphs help readers find information quickly (▶▶ Module 5).

Visuals

- Except for math, construction, and engineering, few classes expect writing to contain anything other than words.
- Business writers are expected to choose the most effective way to convey information. Even a one-page memo may contain a table, graph, or other visual. You'll be expected to be able to use computer programs to create graphs, visuals, and slides for presentations (▶▶ Modules 5, 20, and 25).

What does communication accomplish? LO 1-3

▶ *Management happens through communication.*

According to Henry Mintzberg, managers have three basic jobs: to collect and convey information, to make decisions, and to promote interpersonal unity—that is, to make people want to work together to achieve organizational goals.[13] All of these jobs happen through communication. Effective managers are able to use a wide variety of media and

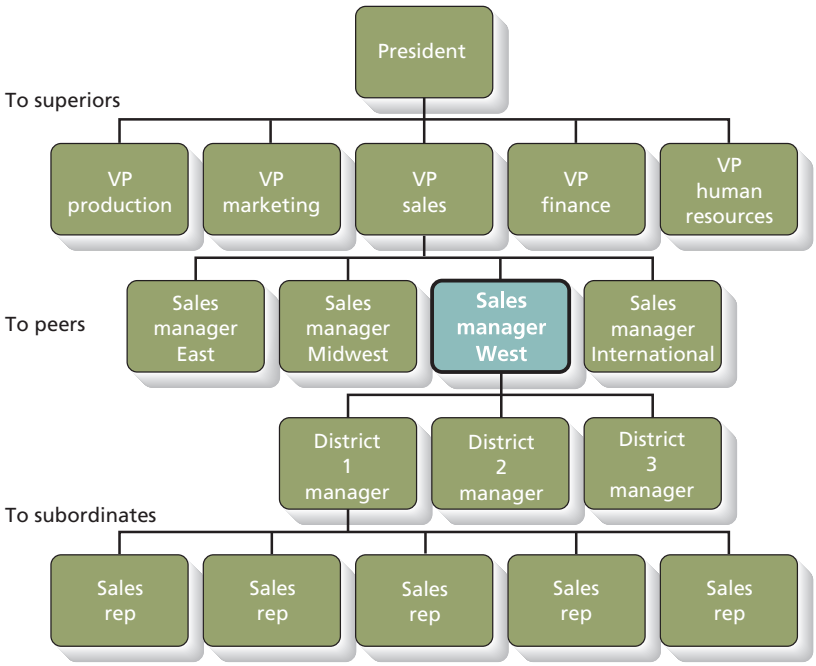


Figure 1.1 The Internal Audiences of the Sales Manager—West

strategies to communicate. They know how to interpret comments from informal channels such as the company grapevine; they can speak effectively in small groups and in formal presentations; they write well.

Communication—oral, nonverbal, and written—goes to both internal and external audiences. **Internal audiences** (Figure 1.1) are other people in the same organization: subordinates, superiors, peers. **External audiences** (Figure 1.2) are people outside the organization: customers, suppliers, unions, stockholders, potential employees, government agencies, the press, and the general public.

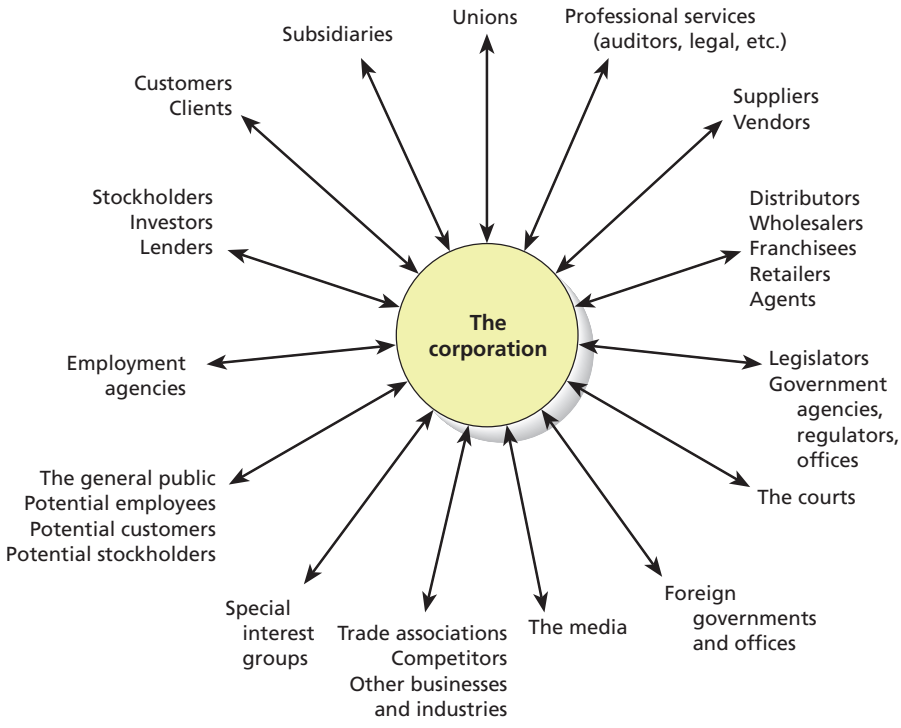


Figure 1.2 The Corporation's External Audiences

Source: Daphne A. Jameson.



Site to See

Go to

www.teslamotors.com

Word-of-mouth rather than traditional advertising has fueled sales of Tesla Motors' electric cars.

The Importance of Listening, Speaking, and Interpersonal Communication

Informal listening, speaking, and working in groups are just as important as writing formal documents and giving formal oral presentations. As a newcomer in an organization, you'll need to listen to others both to find out what you're supposed to do and to learn about the organization's values and culture. Informal chitchat, both about yesterday's game and about what's happening at work, connects you to the **grapevine,** an informal source of company information. You may be asked to speak to small groups, either inside or outside your organization.[14] Networking with others in your office and in town and working with others in workgroups will be crucial to your success.

The Purposes of Messages in Organizations

Instant Replay

Internal and External Audiences

Internal Audiences

Are other people in the same organization: subordinates, superiors, peers.

External Audiences

Are people outside the organization: customers, suppliers, unions, stockholders, potential employees, government agencies, the press, and the general public.

Messages in organizations have one or more of **three basic purposes:** to inform, to request or persuade, and to build goodwill. When you **inform,** you explain something or tell readers something. When you **request or persuade,** you want the reader to act. The word *request* suggests that the action will be easy or routine; *persuade* suggests that you will have to motivate and convince the reader to act. When you **build goodwill,** you create a good image of yourself and of your organization—the kind of image that makes people want to do business with you.

Most messages have multiple purposes.

- When you answer a question, you're informing, but you also want to build goodwill by suggesting that you're competent and perceptive and that your answer is correct and complete.
- In a claims adjustment, whether your answer is yes or no, you want to suggest that the reader's claim has been given careful consideration and that the decision is fair, businesslike, and justified.
- To persuade, a résumé gives information to prove that you're qualified for the job and uses layout to emphasize your strong points and build a good image of you.

How much does correspondence cost? LO 1-4

▶ *$21.15 a page—even more if it doesn't work.*



The international nonprofit organization ProLiteracy estimates that $60 billion is lost annually by American businesses due to issues stemming from illiteracy.

Source: Robert Roy Britt, "14 Percent of U.S. Adults Can't Read," *Livescience,* January 10, 2009, downloaded at http://www.livescience.com/culture/090110-illiterate-adults.html.

Writing costs money. Besides the cost of paper, computers, and software, there is the major expense: employees' time. A consultant who surveyed employees in seven industries found that to prepare a one-page letter, most of them spent 54 minutes planning, composing, and revising the letter. According to the most recent figures from the U.S. Labor Department, employers paid an average of $23.50 per hour per employee for wages and benefits. At that rate, an employer would pay $21.15 for an employee's time spent writing a typical letter.[15] One company in Minneapolis sends out 3,000 original letters a day—worth more than $66,000 at the average rate. A first-class stamp on each letter would add another $1,000 to the company's daily expenses.

In many organizations, all external documents must be approved before they go out. A document may **cycle** from writer to superior to writer to another superior to writer again three or four or many more times before it is finally approved. The cycling process increases the cost of correspondence.

Longer documents can involve large teams of people and take months to write. An engineering firm that relies on military contracts for its business calculates that it spends $500,000 to put together an average proposal and $1 million to write a large proposal.[16]

Poor correspondence costs even more. When writing isn't as good as it could be, you and your organization pay a price in wasted time, wasted efforts, and lost goodwill.

Bad writing wastes time by

- Taking more time to read.
- Requiring more time to revise and causing more rounds of revision.
- Confusing ideas so that discussions and decisions are needlessly drawn out.
- Delaying action while the reader asks for more information or tries to figure out the meaning.

Ineffective messages don't get results. A reader who has to guess what the writer means may guess wrong. A reader who finds a letter or memo unconvincing or insulting simply won't do what the message asks. Thus, second and third and fourth requests are necessary.

Whatever the literal content of the words, every letter, memo, and report serves either to enhance or to damage the image the reader has of the writer. Poor messages damage business relationships.

Good communication is worth every minute it takes and every penny it costs. For instance, the consulting firm Watson Wyatt Worldwide conducted research showing greater returns to shareholders in companies with the most effective programs for communicating with their employees. Those companies also enjoyed lower employee turnover and a 30% increase in their stocks' market value.[17]



A typo may have led to the Wall Street chaos in 2010 that ultimately cost investors billions of dollars. At heart was a $16 million trade in Procter & Gamble stock, but someone entered it as $16 billion instead. In just 15 minutes, the Dow Jones average sank more than 700 points, losing nearly 1,000 points before finally stabilizing at a loss of 347 points.

Source: David Louie, "Typo May Have Been Cause of Market Meltdown," *ABC Channel 7 News,* May 7, 2010, http://abclocal.go.com/kgo/story?section=news/business&id=7427822.

What makes a message effective? LO 1-5

► *Good messages meet five criteria.*

Good business and administrative writing

- **Is clear.** The meaning the reader gets is the meaning the writer intended. The reader doesn't have to guess.
- **Is complete.** All of the reader's questions are answered. The reader has enough information to evaluate the message and act on it.
- **Is correct.** All of the information in the message is accurate. The message is free from errors in punctuation, spelling, grammar, word order, and sentence structure.
- **Saves the reader's time.** The style, organization, and visual impact of the message help the reader to read, understand, and act on the information as quickly as possible.
- **Builds goodwill.** The message presents a positive image of the writer and his or her organization. It treats the reader as a person, not a number. It cements a good relationship between the writer and the reader (►► Modules 6–8).

Whether a message meets these five criteria depends on **the interactions among the writer, the audience, the purposes of the message, and the situation.** No single set of words will work in all possible situations.

Better writing helps you to

- **Save time.** Reduce reading time, since comprehension is easier. Eliminate the time now taken to rewrite badly written materials. Reduce the time taken asking writers, "What did you mean?"
- **Make your efforts more effective.** Increase the number of requests that are answered positively and promptly—on the first request. Present your points—to other people in your organization; to clients, customers, and suppliers; to government agencies; to the public—more forcefully.
- **Communicate your points more clearly.** Reduce the misunderstandings that occur when the reader has to supply missing or unclear information. Make the issues clear, so that disagreements can surface and be resolved more quickly.
- **Build goodwill.** Build a positive image of your organization. Build an image of yourself as a knowledgeable, intelligent, capable person.



Central Connecticut State University (CCSU) determined that Washington, D.C., is the most literate city in the United States with a population greater than 250,000, followed by Seattle, Minneapolis, Atlanta, and Boston. While Seattle often tops many lists of literate cities, the CCSU study included web traffic with more traditional factors as education level, bookstore number, library access, and periodical readership. The study's author, John W. Miller, found no correlation between literacy and a city's wealth.

Source: John Metcalf, "America's Most Literate Cities Not Necessarily the Wealthiest," *The Atlantic,* January 26, 2012, http://www.theatlanticcities.com/arts-and-lifestyle/2012/01/americas-most-literate-cities-not-necessarily-wealthiest/1063/#.

How should I analyze business communication situations? LO 1-6

▶ *Try PAIBOC.*

Before you write or speak, you need to understand the situation. Ask yourself the following questions:

- **What's at stake—to whom?** Think not only about your own needs but about the concerns your boss and your readers will have. Your message will be most effective if you think of the entire organizational context—and the larger context of shareholders, customers, and regulators. When the stakes are high, you'll need to take into account people's emotional feelings as well as objective facts.
- **Should you send a message?** Sometimes, especially when you're new on the job, silence is the most tactful response. But be alert for opportunities to learn, to influence, to make your case. You can use communication to build your career.
- **What channel should you use?** Paper documents and presentations are formal and give you considerable control over the message. E-mail, phone calls, and stopping by someone's office are less formal. Oral channels are better for group decision making, allow misunderstandings to be cleared up more quickly, and seem more personal. Sometimes you may need more than one message, in more than one channel.
- **What should you say?** Content for a message may not be obvious. How detailed should you be? Should you repeat information that the audience already knows? The answers will depend upon the kind of document, your purposes, your audiences, and the corporate culture. And you'll have to figure these things out for yourself, without detailed instructions.
- **How should you say it?** How you arrange your ideas—what comes first, what second, what last—and the words you use shape the audience's response to what you say.

When you're faced with a business communication situation, you need to develop a solution that will both **solve the organizational problem and meet the psychological needs of the people involved.** The strategies in this section will help you solve the problems in this book. Almost all of these strategies can also be applied to problems you encounter on the job.

- **Understand the situation.** What are the facts? What additional information might be helpful? Where could you get it?
- **Brainstorm solutions.** Consciously develop several solutions. Then measure them against your audience and purposes: Which solution is likely to work best?

Instant Replay

Documents' Purposes

Documents in organizations have three basic purposes: to inform, to request or persuade, and to build goodwill.

Most documents have more than one purpose.

Instant Replay

Criteria for Effective Messages

Good business and administrative writing is clear, complete, and correct. It saves the reader time, and it builds goodwill.

Whether a message meets these five criteria depends on **the interactions among the writer, the audience, the purposes of the message, and the situation.** No single set of words will work in all possible situations.



People communicate to plan products and services; hire, train, and motivate workers; coordinate manufacturing and delivery; persuade customers to buy; bill them for the sale; and communicate with stakeholders. The Iowa chapter of the Sierra Club honored the Davenport Alcoa plant for its innovative environmental programs. Pictured here is Alcoa employee Shannon Saliard.

Thinking Creatively LO 1-7

Creativity is essential to success in business and business communication. Here are some examples.

- In a risky move, Apple Computer branched into portable digital music players, a market in which it had no significant experience. The results were the iPod, now the de facto standard, and iTunes, a popular online music store. The company then gambled on the iPhone, iTunes Movie Rentals, the MacBook Air, and the iPad, an electronic tablet that Apple touted as "Our most advanced technology in a magical and revolutionary device at an unbelievable price." To maintain its dominance, Apple must continue to innovate.
- W.L. Gore & Associates, maker of GORE-TEX fabrics and Glide dental floss, was named Most Innovative Company by *Fast Company* magazine. Organized more like a university than a corporation, the company prefers egalitarian teams to boss-driven departments, mixes researchers with salespeople and production workers, and prefers small buildings on minicampuses to gigantic complexes. The $1.6 billion company is the brainchild of Wilbert L. Gore, who believed "communication really happens in the carpool," where hierarchies don't stifle free expression.

Thinking creatively often means shedding common paradigms. For instance, when the fledgling Cartoon Network decided to offer programming aimed at 18- to 34-year-olds, it sought writers and producers who ignored standard marketing practice and instead envisioned a block of shows they'd watch.

The result was *Adult Swim,* an after-hours cavalcade of hip satires like *Futurama* and *The Venture Brothers* mixed with Japanese anime series and off-the-wall comedies like *Family Guy* and *Aqua Teen Hunger Force.* During commercial breaks, postmodern spots advertised upcoming shows or challenged viewers' trivia knowledge. Soon, *Adult Swim* was beating the competition—chiefly Jay Leno and David Letterman.

Ways to become more creative include brainstorming, working within limits, and consciously seeking problems or dissonances that need work.

IBM's tips for creativity are even more diverse. Some of them include

- Have a constructive argument.
- Brainstorm with someone 10 years older and someone 10 years younger.
- Clean your desk.
- Come in early—enjoy the quiet.
- Leave the office. Sit with just a pencil and a pad of paper. See what happens.



Question "conventional wisdom," which can rely on myths and stereotypes. Conventional wisdom argues, for instance, that people naturally side with others along racial, ethnic, gender, religious, or socioeconomic lines. Yet, Asian Americans, even those with Chinese ancestors, are at a disadvantage teaching English in China, where Caucasians, regardless of qualifications, are in demand. Barack Obama was the big Democratic winner in the 2008 Iowa Caucus, which had a record turnout of 236,000 voters and was held in a state that is more than 90% white. And Harvard Business School's Noam Wasserman found that by the time a start-up company has raised its third round of funding, 52% of founder CEOs have been replaced, with three-quarters of them fired by the board. The most successful of founders were actually the first ones to get fired.

Sources: "Tougher Days, Bolder Apple," *BusinessWeek,* June 20, 2005, 38–41; Apple, Inc., downloaded on January 29, 2010, at http://www.apple.com/; Brian Braiker, "Thin Is In at Macworld," *Newsweek,* January 15, 2008, downloaded at www.newsweek.com/id/94611; Alan Deutschman, "The Fabric of Creativity," *Fast Company,* December 2004, 54, downloaded at www.fastcompany.com/magazine/89/open_gore.html; Matthew Grimm, "Major Toon Up," *American Demographics,* October 2004, 50–51; Liz Zack, "How IBM Gets Unstuck," *Fast Company,* October 1999, 104; Kevin Zhou, "Where English Teachers Have to Look the Part," *The Los Angeles Times,* October 29, 2007, downloaded at www.latimes.com/business/la-fi-teach29oct29,1,1254303.story?coll=la-headlines-business&ctrack=3&cset=true; and Nitya Venkataraman, "Obama Emerges Victorious in Iowa," *ABC News,* January 4, 2008, downloaded at http://abcnews.go.com/print?id=4082356; and Jessica Bruder, "A Harvard Professor Analyzes Why Start-Ups Fail," *The New York Times,* May 25, 2012, http://boss.blogs.nytimes.com/2012/05/25/a-harvard-professor-analyzes-why-start-ups-fail/.

Figure 1.3 PAIBOC Questions for Analysis

Use the PAIBOC questions to analyze business communication problems:

P What are your purposes in writing or speaking?

A Who is (are) your audience(s)? How do members of your audience differ? What characteristics are relevant to this particular message?

I What information must your message include?

B What reasons or reader benefits can you use to support your position?

O What objection(s) can you expect your reader(s) to have? What negative elements of your message must you deemphasize or overcome?

C How will the context affect reader response? Think about your relationship to the reader, morale in the organization, the economy, the time of year, and any special circumstances.

- **If you want to add or change information, get permission first.** If you have any questions about ideas you want to use, *ask your instructor.* He or she can tell you *before* you write the message.

When you use this book to create messages on the job, you can't change facts. That is, if it's October, you can't pretend that it's April just because it may be easier to think of reader benefits for that time of year. But it may be possible to change habits that your company has fallen into, especially if they no longer serve a purpose. Check with your supervisor to make sure that your departure from company practice is acceptable.

- **Use the PAIBOC questions in Figure 1.3 to analyze your purpose, your audience, and the situation.**

As Figure 1.3 shows, PAIBOC offers an acronym for the questions you need to answer before you begin composing your message. The following discussion lists specific questions you can answer: ▶▶ Modules 10, 11, and 12 for examples of answers to these questions for specific situations.

P What are your **purposes** in writing or speaking?
What must this message do to solve the organizational problem? What must it do to meet your own needs? What do you want your readers to do? To think or feel? List all your purposes, major and minor. Specify *exactly* what you want your reader to know, think, or do. Specify *exactly* what kind of image of yourself and of your organization you want to project.

Even in a simple message, you may have several related purposes: to announce a new policy, to make readers aware of the policy's provisions and requirements and to have them think that the policy is a good one, that the organization cares about its employees, and that you are a competent writer and manager.

A Who is (are) your **audience(s)?** How do the members of your audience differ from each other? What characteristics are relevant to this particular message?
How much does your audience know about your topic? How will audience members respond to your message? Some characteristics of your readers will be irrelevant; focus on ones that matter *for this message.* Whenever you write to several people or to a group (like a memo to all employees), try to identify the economic, cultural, or situational differences that may affect how various subgroups respond to what you have to say.

I What **information** must your message include?
Make a list of the points that must be included; check your draft to make sure you include them all. If you're not sure whether a particular fact must be included, ask your instructor or your boss.

To include information without emphasizing it, put it in the middle of a paragraph or document and present it as briefly as possible.

B What reasons or reader **benefits** can you use to support your position?
Brainstorm to develop reasons for your decision, the logic behind your argument, and possible benefits to readers if they do as you ask. Reasons and reader benefits do not have to be monetary. Making the reader's job easier or more pleasant is a good reader benefit. In an informative or persuasive message, identify at least five reader benefits. In your message, use those you can develop most easily and most effectively.

Be sure the benefits are adapted to your reader. Many people do not identify closely with their companies; the fact that the company benefits from a policy will help the reader only if the savings or profit is passed directly on to the employees. That is rarely the case: Savings and profits are often eaten up by returns to stockholders, bonuses to executives, and investments in plants and equipment or in research and development.

O What **objections** can you expect your reader(s) to have? What negative elements of your message must you deemphasize or overcome?



Instant Replay

Business communications need both to solve the organizational problem and to meet the psychological needs of the people involved.

Some negative elements can only be deemphasized. Others can be overcome. Be creative: Is there any advantage associated with (even though not caused by) the negative? Can you rephrase or redefine the negative to make the reader see it differently?

C How will the **context** affect the reader's response? Think about your relationship to the reader, morale in the organization, the economy, the time of year, and any special circumstances.

Readers may like you or resent you. You may be younger or older than the people you're writing to. The organization may be prosperous or going through hard times; it may have just been reorganized or may be stable. All these different situations will affect what you say and how you say it.

Think about the news, the economy, the weather. Think about the general business and regulatory climate, especially as it affects the organization specified in the problem. Use the real world as much as possible. Think about interest rates, business conditions, and the economy. Is the industry in which the problem is set doing well? Is the government agency in which the problem is set enjoying general support? Think about the time of year. If it's fall when you write, is your business in a seasonal slowdown after a busy summer? Gearing up for the Christmas shopping rush? Or going along at a steady pace unaffected by seasons?

To answer these questions, draw on your experience, your courses, and your common sense. You may want to talk to other students or read *The Wall Street Journal* or look at a company's annual report. Sometimes you may even want to phone a local business person to get information. For instance, if you needed more information to think of reader benefits for a problem set in a bank, you could call a local banker to find out what kinds of services it offers customers and what its rates are for loans.

The remaining modules in this book will show you how to use this analysis to create business messages that meet your needs, the needs of the reader, and the needs of the organization.



Site to See

Go to

www.netflix.com

Netflix made video rentals easier by establishing a monthly fee and eliminating late charges. Later, the company made rentals available by allowing customers to watch them online.



Writing, scholars believe, was invented to record inventories of livestock and grain to calculate taxes.

Source: Denise Schmandt-Besserat, "The Earliest Precursor of Writing," *Scientific American,* 238, no. 6 (1978): 50–59.



Bob Kellaher, a manager of customer service operations at the New Haven Post Office, collects a last-minute tax return. Kellaher dresses as Uncle Sam every year and stands outside the post office collecting tax forms and mail. Because tax season is a particularly stressful time for individuals filing tax returns, even government organizations such as the U.S. Postal Service can benefit from efforts to foster customer satisfaction.

Summary of Learning Objectives

- Communication helps organizations and the people in them achieve their goals. The ability to write and speak well becomes increasingly important as you rise in an organization. **(LO 1-1)**
- People put things in writing to create a record, to convey complex data, to make things convenient for the reader, to save money, and to convey their own messages more effectively. **(LO 1-2)**
- **Internal documents** go to people inside the organization. **External documents** go to audiences outside: clients, customers, suppliers, stockholders, the government, the media, the general public. **(LO 1-3)**
- The three basic purposes of business and administrative communication are **to inform, to request or persuade, and to build goodwill.** Most messages have more than one purpose. **(LO 1-3)**
- A one-page message that took an hour to plan, write, and revise cost on average $21.15. Poor writing costs even more since it wastes time, wastes efforts, and jeopardizes goodwill. **(LO 1-4)**
- Good business and administrative writing meets five basic criteria: it's **clear, complete, and correct; it saves the reader's time;** and it **builds goodwill. (LO 1-5)**
- To evaluate a specific document, we must know the interactions among the writer, the reader(s), the purposes of the message, and the situation. No single set of words will work for all readers in all situations. **(LO 1-6)**
- To understand business communication situations, ask the following questions: **(LO 1-6)**
  - What's at stake—to whom?
  - Should you send a message?
  - What channel should you use?
  - What should you say?
  - How should you say it?
- Use the PAIBOC question to analyze business communication problems: **(LO 1-6)**
  - P What are your **purposes** in writing or speaking?
  - A Who is (are) your **audience(s)?** How do members of your audience differ? What characteristics are relevant to the particular message?
  - I What **information** must your message include?
  - B What reasons or reader **benefits** can you use to support your position?
  - O What **objection(s)** can you expect your reader(s) to have? What negative elements of your message must you deemphasize or overcome?
  - C How will the **context** affect reader response? Think about your relationship to the reader, morale in the organization, the economy, the time of year, and any special circumstances.
- A solution to a business communication problem must both solve the organizational problem and meet the needs of the writer or speaker, the organization, and the audience. **(LO 1-6)**
- To think creatively, brainstorm, work within limits, consciously seek problems that need work, have a constructive argument, clean your desk, come in early, leave the office with a pencil and pad, and question conventional wisdom. **(LO 1-7)**

Assignments for Module 1

Questions for Comprehension

1.1 What are the three basic purposes of business messages? **(LO 1-3)**

1.2 What are the five basic criteria for effective messages? **(LO 1-5)**

1.3 What does PAIBOC stand for? **(LO 1-6)**

Questions for Critical Thinking

1.4 Why do writing and speaking become even more important as people rise in the organization? **(LO 1-1 to LO 1-3)**

1.5 If you're just looking for a low-level job, why is it still useful to be able to write and speak well? **(LO 1-1 to LO 1-3)**

1.6 Why do you need to understand the purposes, audience, and context for a message to know whether a specific set of words will work? **(LO 1-2)**

1.7 What opportunities do you have in volunteer or student organizations to do real "business writing" while you're in school? **(LO 1-5)**

Exercises and Problems

1.8 Discussing Strengths (LO 1-5, LO 1-6)

Introduce yourself to a small group of other students. Identify three of your strengths that might interest an employer. These can be experience, knowledge, or personality traits (like enthusiasm).

1.9 Introducing Yourself to Your Instructor (LO 1-5, LO 1-6)

Write a memo (at least 1½ pages long) introducing yourself to your instructor. Include the following topics:

- Background: Where did you grow up? What have you done in terms of school, extracurricular activities, jobs, and family life?

- Interests: What are you interested in? What do you like to do? What do you like to think about and talk about?
- Achievements: What achievements have given you the greatest personal satisfaction? List at least five. Include things that gave you a real sense of accomplishment and pride, whether or not they're the sort of thing you'd list on a résumé.
- Goals: What do you hope to accomplish this term? Where would you like to be professionally and personally five years from now?

Use complete memo format with appropriate headings. (►► Module 9 for examples of memo format.) Use a conversational writing style; check your draft to polish the style and edit for mechanical and grammatical correctness. A good memo will enable your instructor to see you as an individual. Use specific details to make your memo vivid and interesting. Remember that one of your purposes is to interest your reader!

1.10 Describing Your Experiences in and Goals for Writing (LO 1-5, LO 1-6)

Write a memo (at least 1½ pages long) to your instructor describing the experiences you've had writing and what you'd like to learn about writing during this course.

Answer several of the following questions:

- What memories do you have of writing? What made writing fun or frightening in the past?
- What have you been taught about writing? List the topics, rules, and advice you remember.
- What kinds of writing have you done in school? How long have the papers been?
- How has your school writing been evaluated? Did the instructor mark or comment on mechanics and grammar? Style? Organization? Logic? Content? Audience analysis and adaptation? Have you gotten extended comments on your papers? Have instructors in different classes had the same standards, or have you changed aspects of your writing for different classes?
- What voluntary writing have you done—journals, poems, stories, essays? Has this writing been just for you, or has some of it been shared or published?
- Have you ever written on a job or in a student or volunteer organization? Have you ever typed other people's writing? What have these experiences led you to think about real-world writing?
- What do you see as your current strengths and weaknesses in writing skills? What skills do you think you'll need in the future? What kinds of writing do you expect to do after you graduate?

Use complete memo format with appropriate headings. (►► Module 9 for examples of memo format.) Use a conventional writing style; edit your final draft for mechanical and grammatical correctness.

1.11 Letters to Angry Electric Company Customers (LO 1-5 to LO 1-7)

Your regional electric utility provides power to rural, urban, and suburban customers. Recently, a series of heavy summer rainstorms knocked out electricity to thousands of customers. Because overhead power lines came down—in some cases due to inadequate tree trimming by home owners—some customers were without power for more than a week. In addition to the inconvenience of not having electricity, many customers also had to throw away spoiled food, as well as go without air conditioning on days when temperatures climbed past 90 degrees.

Today, you receive a letter from Harper Henry, a longtime customer and local business leader whose husband, Stephen D'Amico, is a county commissioner. Ms. Henry is angry that power to her neighborhood was out for four days and that though similar storms have knocked out power in past years, nothing seems to have been done to prepare for future storms. In particular, there is no plan to bury overhead power lines. "Your company puts making money ahead of customer service," she writes. "You continue to post record profits while putting countless lives at stake, all for the sake of your bottom line."

The following letters are possible approaches to answering this complaint. How well does each message meet the needs of the reader, the writer, and the organization? Is the message clear, complete, and correct? Does it save the reader's time? Does it build goodwill?

1.

Dear Sir or Madam:

You opinion is valuable to us, and you can rest assured that we are looking into the problem. Should you have questions or concerns in the future, please do not hesitate to contact us.

2.

Dear Harper:

You're right — we dropped the ball on this one! But the utility business is an unpredictable one, and only God Himself controls the weather. So, while we deal with the frustration of being mere mortals, you can help us with your patience. Make sure, too, that you trim any trees that are on your property and are close to overhead power lines since falling trees caused a lot of the problems. With any luck, we'll all be better off in the next storm.

P.S. How funny that someone named Harper would be sending a letter to complain!

3.

Dear Mrs. Henry:

The electric utility business is a particularly difficult one. You'd be surprised at all of the variables that come into play. For instance, there are union contracts to negotiate with employees. Did you know that we can't expect a lineman to work more than eight hours in one day without doubling his hourly rate? We also have to provide meals if the work goes beyond 12 hours and overnight accommodations if the worker must travel more than 50 miles from home. All that's just part of the labor issue. Unions are killing this business.

There's also the cost of producing the electricity, meeting the government regulations for clean air in our coal-fired plants, and upkeep of the overhead power lines. As you know, we trim trees that are within 10 feet of any power line, but home owners are responsible for the other trees. Do they trim them? Of course not. Then a good wind comes along and knocks them down, right onto those lines. It's a crazy business, Mrs. Henry, and one that is a miracle to make any money in.

Anyway, we're sorry for the inconvenience you faced. But I'm sure you can now see just how challenging all this is. Think about that the next time you flip a switch. This is what we do so you can have light to read by and television to watch. Your electric company is on your side.

4.

Dear Ms. Henry:

Thank you for your recent feedback regarding the power outage to your home.

As you know, the storms that hit this year were particularly powerful. Hundreds of miles of overhead power lines were brought down in a matter of minutes, leaving thousands of customers stranded. Though more than 1,500 extra utility workers from surrounding states were brought in to help restore electricity, clearly we could have done better. Going without electricity for even a few minutes is too long, and we are making strides to improve our service.

We are currently working with local municipalities to explore cost-effective ways to solve this problem. Suggestions from valuable customers like you will help in the effort. As you noted in your letter, burying power lines is an option to consider.

Your loyalty and input will help us to provide even better service to customers.

1.12 Online Messages for Discussion—Responding to Rumors (LO 1-5 to LO 1-7)

The Acme Corporation has been planning to acquire Best Products, and Acme employees are worried about how the acquisition will affect them. Ed Zeplin, Acme's human resource manager, has been visiting the message boards on job search sites like Vault.com and sees a dramatic rise in the number of messages posted by people claiming to be Acme employees. Many of the messages are spreading rumors about layoffs, and most of the rumors are false.

The following messages are possible responses that Ed can post to the message boards. How well does each message meet the needs of the reader, the writer, and the organization? Is the message clear, complete, and correct? Does it save the reader's time? Does it build goodwill?

1.

It Will Be Great!
Author: L. Ed Zeplin, HR
Date: Tuesday, May 23

I am happy to tell you that the HR news is good. Two months ago, the CEO told me about the merger, and I have been preparing a human resource plan ever since.

I want you to know about this because morale has been bad, and it shouldn't be. You really should wait for the official announcements, and you'll see that the staffing needs will remain strong. My department has been under a lot of pressure, but if you'll be patient, we'll explain everything—the staffing, the compensation.

Our plan should be ready by Monday, and then if you have any questions, just contact your HR rep.

2.

HR Staffing
Author: HR Boss
Date: Tuesday, May 23

The rumors are false. Just ask anyone in HR. There will be no layoffs.

3.

Don't Believe the Rumors
Author: lezeplin@acme.com
Date: Tuesday, May 23

Acme has 475 employees, and Best Products has 132 employees. Our human resource plan for next year calls for 625 employees. If you do the math, you can see that there will be no layoffs. Rather, we will be hiring 20 employees. Of course, as we consolidate operations with Best, there will be some redeployments. However, our plan indicates that we will be able to retain our current staff. All employees are valued at Acme, as our current benefits package testifies.

Our HR plan is based on the best analytic techniques and a business forecast by a top consulting firm. If you're an employee, you should review our business plan, at the Our Goals page on Acme's intranet. Everyone should read Acme's mission statement on our home page, www.acme.com/homepage.html.

4.

Layoff Rumors Do Acme a Disservice
Author: Zeplin in HR
Date: Tuesday, 23 May

If you come here to get your company information, you aren't getting the straight story. The people posting to this discussion board are spreading false rumors, not the truth. If you want to know the truth about Acme, ask the people who have access to the information.

As HR manager, I can assure you we won't be laying off employees after the merger with Best Products. I'm the one who approves the staffing plan, so I should know. If people would ask me, instead of reading the negative, whining lies at this site, they would know the facts, too.

If people really cared about job security, they would be meeting and exceeding their work goals, rather than wasting their time in rumor-mongering on message boards. Hard work: that's the key to success!

5.

The True Story about Lay-Offs
Author: lezeplin@acme.com
Date: Tuesday, 23 May

Whenever there is a merger or acquisition, rumors fly. It's human nature to turn to rumors when a situation seems uncertain. The case of Acme acquiring Best Products is no exception, so I'm not surprised to see rumors about layoffs posted on this message board.

Have no fear! I am working closely with our CEO and with the CEO and human resource manager at Best Products, and we all agree that our current staff is a valuable asset to Acme, to Best, and to our combined companies in the future. We have no plans to lay off any of our valued people. I will continue monitoring this message board and will post messages as I am able to disclose more details about our staffing plans. In the meantime, employees should watch for official information in the company newsletter and on our intranet.

We care about our people! If employees ever have questions about our plans and policies, they should contact me directly.

L. Ed Zeplin, HR Manager



Polishing Your Prose

Sentence Fragments

A complete sentence has a subject and a verb. If either the subject or the verb is missing, the result is a sentence fragment.

The job candidates.
Passed seven rounds of interviews.
And have taken three tests.

To fix the fragment, join it to other words to make a complete sentence.

The job candidates passed seven rounds of interviews and have taken three tests.

Sentence fragments also occur when a clause has both a subject and a verb but is unable to stand by itself as a complete sentence.

Although I read my e-mail
Because she had saved her work
If he upgrades his computer

The words *although, because,* and *since* make the clause subordinate, which means the clause cannot stand alone. It must be joined to a main clause.

Although I read my e-mail, I did not respond to the draft of the proposal.

Because she had saved her work, Paula was able to restore it after the crash.

If he upgrades his computer, he will be able to use the new software.

Words that make clauses subordinate are

after	if
although, though	when, whenever
because, since	while, as
before, until	

Even sentences that have a subject and verb and are not subordinate may seem fragmentary in thought.

The computer is.
I need.
She transfers.

Add more information to make the sentence clear.

The computer is the latest model.
I need more letterhead.
She transfers to the logistics department on Tuesday.

Sometimes fragments are OK. For instance, fragments are used in résumés, advertisements, and some sales and fund-raising letters. However, fragments are inappropriate for most business documents. Because they are incomplete, they can confuse or mislead readers.

But the biggest problem with grammatical errors like sentence fragments is that readers sometimes assume that people who make errors are unprofessional or unpromotable (▶▶ Module 14). Of course, using "incorrect" grammar has nothing to do with intelligence, but many people nevertheless use grammar as a yardstick. People who cannot measure up to that yardstick may be stuck in low-level jobs.

Exercises

Make the following sentence fragments into complete sentences.

1. Making the most of a difficult situation.
2. The latest word processing app.
3. Mia, who recently graduated from business school.
4. Because Terrence will be in Portland for the day.
5. Downloading a patch for that software glitch.
6. Whenever Joyce gets a chance to review the file.
7. The vice president of our Chicago office, Ajay Sajda.
8. More than 20 years of IT experience, including consulting overseas.
9. Tweeted an invitation for the reception at the Four Seasons Hotel.
10. Chloe, certain the manufacturing license will be granted by July 2.

Check your answers to the odd-numbered exercises at the back of the book.